

Triangle Down

(Crash/Retrieval on the East German Border)

Sometime between May 1, and May 5, 1989 a historical event occurred which has never been published in either American or overseas aerospace trade publications. This event concerns the crash and recovery of a classified “black” aircraft believed to have been procured by the American aerospace industry (specifically southern California). Now, for the first time, details have emerged which finally shed light on one of the most elusive “mystery aircraft” ever to have been built during the cold war era.

Skimming the terrain at tree-top level the pilot of a two-man super-secret aircraft accidentally clipped the top of a pine tree and crashed ten kilometers southwest of Halle East Germany. It's not known if this was due to a miscalculation within the onboard navigation system or pilot error. Both crew members survived the crash, which took place among rolling hills and tall field grass. Patches of snow and small bushes surrounded the site with various debris spread around the point of impact. Specific details provided by a Medic who participated in the retrieval operation indicated that the craft resembled an isosceles triangle with a width of ten feet, and an overall length of twenty four feet. The exterior texture and color of the vehicle was identical to that of an F-117A Stealth Fighter. Its pyramidal shaped flat surface design and black appearance added to its mystique. It had no wings, visible engine, or conventional control surfaces of any kind. Its unique configuration and propulsion system layout required it to fly blunt end forward (against conventional wisdom).

Upon impact, the forward left portion of the craft was damaged which crumpled its carbon fiber structure. A significant hull breach occurred near the aft 1/3 of the craft causing it to protrude at a fifteen degree angle. At this point of fracture, a fine mesh of golden colored wires could be seen which were integrated into the structure. These may have been built into the vehicle to reduce its RCS (Radar Cross Section). A standard issue USAF gray colored “stars and bars” insignia was also located just ahead of the breach. One of the hydraulic pistons used to lift the canopy was broken which may have caused significant difficulties for the crew members during emergency egress. Two triangular “DANGER” labels appeared immediately below the canopy supporting structure. Of special interest were three two foot diameter white spheres which had the external texture that resembled a scalloped sea-shell or terra-cotta roof. Each sphere was neatly integrated into the lower body of the craft, and included a two-pronged clasp device which held them in place. The clasp was silver/gray in color. It's believed that these spheres were a primary part of the vehicle's propulsion system, and that the clasps served as a sort of “fly-by-wire” flight control system. The crew compartment consisted of an F-16 control stick with a standard HUD (Head's up display).

By morning, the retrieval operation was already in full gear with members of the 160th SOAR (Special Operations Airborne Reconnaissance) team surrounding the crash site. Two Blackhawk and one fully armed Apache helicopter provided security and logistical support. A CH-53 Super Stallion was called in to recover the remaining sphere which had been ejected on impact. It was transported away from the debris field via a 120 foot long composite nylon cable which was attached to an Aluminum equipment case. Two Mercedes Benz delivery style trucks were also instrumental in retrieving the debris. When the clean-up operation had been completed, the primary structure of the craft was burned to the ground by two incendiary grenades which destroyed any sensitive components associated with the craft.

Considering its flat smooth sides and inky black exterior color, it's reasonable to conclude that this unusual craft was built at Lockheed's "Skunk Works" facility in Burbank California. Preliminary design was probably completed sometime around 1986, with the first flight occurring in 1988. Descriptions of the canopy and interior cockpit details support this assessment. It was more than likely funded by the so called "black budget" procured during the Reagan administration, and may have been an advanced "off-shoot" of the F-117A Stealth Fighter program.